

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 1: *The Search for Glory*¹

This book study is designed to give you an overview of the first eleven chapters of *Neurosis and Human Growth*, written by Dr. Karen Horney. The material is dense and somewhat difficult, so Nancy has created simple reading guides to help you identify the main points. Many KF members continue to attend this course year after year because it is not possible to absorb all the information at once. You may find this limitation frustrating or discouraging. Be kind to yourself and allow the information to gently seep into your mind and gradually expand your understanding. Just focus on a few points. Talk about what you are learning with your *Karis Link*, the person who invited you to the study, and then come back again to absorb some more.

For over two decades, Nancy has been actively applying the principles of *Neurosis and Human Growth* to her own life and to the lives of many others. During that time, she has discovered that the themes described in this book consistently correlate with what the Bible teaches about the condition of mankind and the hope of the gospel of Jesus Christ. With the Bible in one hand and *Neurosis and Human Growth* in the other, Nancy has guided hundreds of people in the process of healing their lives and fulfilling their potential.

Dr. Horney first published her definition and analysis of the neurotic psyche in the 1940s, and her research and conclusions about why we think, feel, and do the things that we do are still very valuable for us today. As you study this material, you may begin to identify neurotic tendencies in other people, and that is a great start. Our goal for this course, however, is to recognize the neurosis in ourselves so that we can begin to change the direction of our own lives. Only you can change the person you are. Karis Fellowships training will guide and support you as you go through that process.

You may not like the term *neurosis*. It is a term used in psychoanalysis to describe the condition of anyone who is motivated by compelling needs and ambitious pride—forces that inevitably present obstacles to personal growth and wellbeing. By contrast, healthy people live spontaneously out of their created design, which leads them to fulfill their potential. In Karis Fellowships, we find it helpful to use the term *misorientation* rather than *neurosis* because when we are neurotic, we are not oriented to God or to His design, nor can we develop the person He created us to be. As neurotics, we have misoriented toward a pseudo-person that we have constructed as a survival tool, and that pseudo-person has inflated into an idol-god full of demands and restrictions. This self-created god rules us with more authority than the real God, and that's why we find it so hard to live lives of peace, increasing potential, and consistent joy that the real God promises us. In this study, we will come face to face with the disturbing fact that we are often serving the wrong god.

The wrong god, or Idol Self, compels us to make unrealistic and even self-destructive choices in a frenzied attempt to satisfy its craving for false glory and achieve a sense of superiority and significance. By enforcing its own carefully constructed system of laws and punishments, it asserts its own values and goals while constantly seeking to suppress the real self, the self that God created. Our idealized self, or Idol Self, has definite and very rigid opinions about how life should be and how things should go. Life is full of difficulties and surprises, so this Idol Self is chronically fearful, anxious, strained, and frustrated. This false self is not interested in the truth about you or others. Its sole aim is to save its idealized life.

Neurosis and Human Growth was written to help psychoanalysts identify the problem of neurosis in patients, but it does not really offer a solution. Karis Fellowships training offers a solution, and recognizing that there is an Idol Self is the first step.

We hope that you will make this study a priority as you begin to uncover the secret forces that are driving your life. We would like to remind you again that regular attendance and completing the NHG reading guides is the necessary prerequisite for joining the Karis Fellowship training groups. KF training is not as arduous or time-consuming as the NHG study. KF members learn to take from the training what works for them today, and they celebrate together their progress toward a real life which promotes increasing peace and potential in every area of life.

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).